At that point of time, Bomdila was still under Indian control only because the Chinese had still not showed up. After threatening Gurbax Singh with a court martial unless he sent out the armoured patrol, there was not much left for Bijji Kaul and the other two senior officers to do.

The DMO then stated that the time had come for them to make a plan for the defence of Assam. ‘We must forsee the possibility of the Chinese capturing Bomdila, in which case the whole of the Missamari-Charduar-Tezpur area would be threatened. At the same time, a smaller enemy thrust from Walong must also be expected after a period of build-up.’

Palit was stating the obvious. The army commander, however, was not in any mood for a discussion. Bogey Sen stated that he had no more troops left and therefore he could not make any plans. Palit, by now completely disillusioned by Sen’s refusal to take charge, stuck to his guns: ‘The Chinese threat to the plains will not materialize immediately,’ he said, ‘there is bound to be a brief respite during which time we must reorganize and, if necessary, get further reinforcements from the Punjab.’

Fortunately, General Thapar, more to avoid a full-blown argument between his army commander and his DMO, told Palit to go ahead and draw up a plan for further discussion between him, the army commander and the corps commander. A reluctant Kaul then moved to a far corner of the Ops Room to sit down with Palit to do a hurried assessment of the forces available and to indicate guidelines for action.

5 Division had already been earmarked to move from the Punjab and orders were issued for the immediate move by air to Tezpur (leading elements of the division would start arriving the next day). In addition, on the north bank of the Brahmaputra, 181 Brigade along with a squadron of armour was stationed at Daranga while there were close to 6,000 other troops from various support units who could be organized to take on any Chinese raiding parties until further re-enforcements arrived. One brigade from 23 Division was expected to be at Jorhat shortly while two more brigades were on their way to join up with the remnants of 11 Brigade as a part of 2 Division. In addition, there were Assam Rifles and armed police units that could be brought into play if required. Should the Chinese regroup and follow up on their success in the Kameng Frontier Division, these forces would then have to fight a series of delaying actions westwards, backing up towards the Siliguri corridor.